
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Sturdy defence puts Gunners on top

"One-nil to the Arsenal" may not be thrilling but it is certainly effective. Sunday's victory over Crystal Palace was Mikel Arteta's side's third by that margin in nine Premier League games. Last season, Arsenal managed that result five times in the league, while also drawing 1-1 in seven matches. Clean sheets in just half of those might have made for an intriguing title race. For all the noise surrounding Arsenal's attacking talent, their defence is just as vital. It is their solidity at that end of the pitch that will probably lead them to glory, with three goals conceded in nine top-flight games so far. Sunday also marked a century of games across all competitions since they have conceded more than twice. The last to put three past David Raya? Luton – remember them? – back [in December 2023](#). **Sam Dalling**

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Match report: [Arsenal 1-0 Crystal Palace](#)

Elliott must wait for a chance

Aston Villa earned a statement victory against Manchester City to make it four straight top-flight wins but Harvey Elliott, who joined from Liverpool last month in search of game time, was a high profile absentee. Unai Emery explained Elliott's performances across a total of 167 minutes in a Villa shirt simply did not warrant a place in the matchday squad, particularly given the return to form of Morgan Rogers and the rebirth of Emiliano Buendía, who was forced off against City approaching the half-hour and left Villa Park on crutches. Elliott was withdrawn at half-time on his sole league start for Villa, against his former club Fulham last month, and last featured as a 86th-minute substitute at Feyenoord at the start of October. Elliott left Anfield in search of regular minutes but has found them hard to come by. "I spoke with him about it," Emery said. "My advice was: keep going. He is a very good player. Our demands are on a high level. He needs time to work and wait for his moment."

Ben Fisher

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Match report: [Aston Villa 1-0 Man City](#)

Kayode offers more than long throws

The temptation with a player such as Michael Kayode is to overprioritise the aspect of the game at which he is exceptional, which is to say his long throws. But even without the prodigious distance he can hurl a ball, the 21-year-old Italian is an extremely promising full-back. He has the physicality and energy of the modern defender and, while it may be more chaotic than graceful, his dribbling style is effective. Again and again against Liverpool, his forward surges carried [Brentford](#) out of trouble and created opportunities. Sometimes he ended up on the left and never seemed entirely comfortable shooting with his left foot, but Kayode did play two important passes, two-thirds of his crosses found a Brentford player and he ended up with a passing accuracy of 87%. He has started every league game, allowing Kristoffer Ajer to move to the left, with Keane Lewis-Potter becoming an option off the bench. **Jonathan Wilson**

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Match report: [Brentford 3-2 Liverpool](#)

Mbeumo and Cunha clicking for United

After Bryan Mbeumo's double took [Manchester United](#) to a third consecutive Premier League win on Saturday night, the forward said he was aiming to emulate last season's 20 league goals for Brentford – or do even better. "I try to not set limits on myself, on what I can reach. I'm just going to work and try to do as best as possible," said the Cameroon international, who has four goals in nine league appearances, and five in 10 in all competitions for United. Matheus Cunha's fine opener from distance against Brighton was the Brazilian's first goal, 10 games in for Ruben Amorim's team, easing pressure on him. "I think he took some off his shoulders today," Mbeumo said. "He was waiting for it. We were waiting for it for him as well. So we are very happy for him." **Jamie Jackson**

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Match report: [Manchester United 4-2 Brighton](#)

Van de Ven steps up for Spurs

Without the services of the injured captain, Cristian Romero, among others, there were concerns from Tottenham fans that they might lose their undefeated road record at Everton. They need not have worried as the Dutch giant Micky van de Ven stepped into the Romero-shaped void and more than filled it. Van de Ven was handed the captain's armband at Hill Dickinson Stadium and the 6ft 4in defender responded by muscling in two headers from set plays to take his tally to five goals in all competitions. Perhaps concerningly, he is now out on his own as Tottenham's top scorer this season. Van de Ven was also required to show the kind of basic defensive instincts that Spurs lacked under Ange Postecoglou. As part of a back line that made 53 clearances, Van de Ven excelled. Playing on the road suits Thomas Frank's team. They do not need to make the running, can sit in defensively and fall back on set pieces for their threat. At home against [Chelsea](#) on Saturday, Spurs and Van de Ven will need to show their more expansive side, especially if Romero is still absent. **Tom Bassam**

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Match report: [Everton 0-3 Tottenham](#)

Chelsea feel Palmer's absence in defeat

This was the first time Chelsea have properly felt the absence of Cole Palmer this season. They have mostly coped well during the playmaker's absence with a persistent groin problem but they needed his ingenuity during their 2-1 home defeat against Sunderland. João Pedro, operating in Palmer's No 10 position, was poor and has been out of form for a while, while Enzo Maresca's wide players were largely blunt and predictable. "We didn't create a lot," said the Chelsea manager, who continues to encounter problems against teams who set up with low blocks. The hosts did not move the ball with enough speed and they ran out of ideas long before the end, and Sunderland's stoppage-time winner. The concern with Maresca is that his football sometimes becomes rigid and formulaic. Palmer has the imagination to open up stubborn defences by altering angles and doing the unexpected. He was missed on Saturday; Chelsea are eagerly awaiting his return. **Jacob Steinberg**

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Match report: [Chelsea 1-2 Sunderland](#)

Adams hitting the heights for Iraola

Tyler Adams had been a slow burner for [Bournemouth](#) but in the past 12 months, since recovering from back surgery, the American has become vital for Andoni Iraola. His energy in midfield was a leading reason for Nottingham Forest finding space so tight, and it was his robbing of Elliot Anderson that led to Junior Kroupi scoring the second, clinching goal. Alongside him, Alex Scott was given free hand to add his loose-limbed creativity to attack. Where last season, Iraola was often down to bare bones, at one point capable of fielding only 12 senior players, he now has options for the battles ahead. Ryan Christie and Lewis Cook, previous constants, were kept in reserve. "I have to take even more difficult decisions," said a manager granted the novel luxury of choice – "internal competition", as he termed it. On current form, his performance against Forest the latest demonstration of his box-to-box capabilities, Adams appears to be an easy selection. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [Bournemouth 2-0 Nottingham Forest](#)

Win on the road boosts Clarets' hopes

Now five points clear of the bottom three, [Burnley](#) picked up their first away win this season at Molineux. For a side that set a second-tier record on the road last season with 49 points and 14 wins, fans might have hoped it would not take the Clarets this long to secure points away from Turf Moor in the top flight. That being said, Scott Parker's side conceded 16 goals in 46 games last season; they have leaked one more so far this season in 37 fewer matches. Such is the difference in level between the two divisions, but that does not have to be a negative for Burnley. Three important points, taken right at the death after losing a two-goal lead, adds to the tally and puts them in 16th – eight points above their winless opponents. **Peter Lansley**

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Match report: [Wolves 2-3 Burnley](#)

Shirt-pulling is still going unchecked

At the start of this season, there was a big song and dance about referees supposedly [clamping down on holding and shirt-pulling](#). The clocks have only just gone back but that initiative seems to have gone the way of the late summer sun. Anyone seeking confirmation of this only needed to be at St James' Park on Saturday to see Nick Woltemade's shirt tugged so hard, and so persistently, by Fulham's Issa Diop and Calvin Bassey that the only surprise was the fabric did not tear. The Newcastle centre-forward's gangly 6ft 6in frame – allied to his preference for wearing slightly oversized tops – dictates there is plenty of shirt for his markers to pull, but surely referees should be offering Woltemade more protection? The German's technical skills are a joy to watch and he should have been afforded more freedom to express them on a day when Bruno Guimarães's 90th-minute goal secured Eddie Howe's side a much needed win, and consigned Fulham to a fourth straight defeat. **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Newcastle 2-1 Fulham](#)

Calvert-Lewin proving an asset for Leeds

Goals are hard to come by for Dominic Calvert-Lewin, who has scored only once since joining Leeds on a free transfer this summer. However, the former Everton striker has quickly become critical to Daniel Farke's structure and style of play, despite his struggles in front of goal. Sending direct passes down the pitch for Calvert-Lewin to either hold up or flick on was a regular feature of the victory against West Ham. It helped relieve the pressure the visitors were putting Leeds under, offering an ideal outlet. There is plenty of focus on set pieces under Farke and Calvert-Lewin is a constant threat when the ball is sent into the box. Out of contract at Everton, Calvert-Lewin took a long time to find a new club but he may have found the right one at Elland Road. He offered plenty of endeavour on Friday but did not receive the level of service a striker needs to thrive. If he can add goals soon, he will become an even greater asset. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Leeds 2-1 West Ham](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	9	13	22
2	AFC Bournemouth	9	5	18
3	Tottenham Hotspur	9	10	17
4	Sunderland	9	4	17
5	Man City	9	10	16
6	Man Utd	9	1	16
7	Liverpool	9	2	15
8	Aston Villa	9	1	15
9	Chelsea	9	6	14
10	Crystal Palace	9	3	13
11	Brentford	9	0	13
12	Newcastle	9	1	12
13	Brighton	9	-1	12
14	Everton	9	-3	11
15	Leeds	9	-5	11
16	Burnley	9	-5	10
17	Fulham	9	-5	8
18	Nottm Forest	9	-12	5
19	West Ham	9	-13	4
20	Wolverhampton	9	-12	2

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